Nourish to Restore

Nutrition for your return to movement

Your body has done something extraordinary. Before we think about getting stronger, it needs fuel to heal. This isn't the time for dieting: it's the time for nourishing.

These tips are firmly evidence-based, drawn from current NHS and UK nutrition guidance, to help your body heal, recover and grow stronger, one stage at a time.

STAGE 1

Heal

Foundations & Core Basics (Videos 1–2)

- **Eat regularly.** Three meals and two or three snacks keep energy and blood sugar steady through broken nights.
- **Protein at every meal.** A palm-sized portion (about 20–25g): eggs, Greek yoghurt, fish, chicken, lentils, tofu. Protein, vitamin C and zinc help tissue repair, including C-section scars.
- **Fibre and fluids.** Straining puts pressure on a healing pelvic floor and abdominal wall. Oats, fruit, veg, beans and water help.

STAGE 2

Build

Full Body Strength (Video 3)

- **Increase protein slightly** to about 25–30g per meal, plus a protein-rich snack after you train. Your muscles are now rebuilding.
- **Fuel your workouts.** A small snack 60–90 minutes before (banana and nut butter, toast and egg), so you're not training on empty.

STAGE 3

Strengthen

Return to Studio (Video 4)

- **Spread protein across the day**, at every meal and snack.
- **Add slow-release carbohydrates** (oats, rice, potatoes, wholegrain bread) on studio days, to power your sessions and recovery.

Every day, at every stage

- **Hydration.** Breastfeeding adds roughly 700ml to your daily needs. Keep a glass of water by you at every feed, and aim for pale yellow urine.
- **Vitamin D.** The NHS recommends **10µg (400 IU) a day** for all breastfeeding mums, all year round. It's essential for your bones and your baby's.
- **Calcium.** Breastfeeding increases your needs to about **1,250mg a day**: milk, yoghurt, cheese, calcium-fortified plant milks, calcium-set tofu, and tinned fish with soft bones.
- **Iron.** Blood loss at birth can leave you depleted. Include red meat, lentils, beans and leafy greens, with vitamin C to help absorption. Exhausted, breathless or dizzy? Ask your GP to check your iron.
- **Omega-3 and iodine.** 1–2 portions of oily fish a week (no more than 2 while breastfeeding), plus dairy and eggs for iodine. Plant-based? Choose iodine-fortified milk and an algae-based omega-3.
- **Breastfeeding?** You need roughly **330 extra calories a day**. Milk supply and recovery come first, so save any weight-loss goals until you're feeling strong.
- **Caffeine.** No more than **200mg a day** (about two mugs of coffee) while breastfeeding.

> **Look after yourself.** Batch cook, keep one-handed snacks within reach, and accept every offer of a meal. If your mood feels low, if eating feels difficult, or if you have any health concerns, speak to your GP, health visitor or a registered nutritionist.

Written by Nesse Cannon, clinical nutritionist (MSc Clinical Nutrition, AfN-registered ANutr), founder of HerSpace London.

This guidance is general information, not medical advice. Always check with your GP or midwife before starting supplements or exercise after birth.